On 1 September, Ratan met Mistry in Pune. During, the meeting, Mistry informed Ratan that Aggarwal had sought a meeting with him and that he would schedule it shortly. But there was no meaningful progress. A disappointed Ratan wrote to Mistry on 16 September, expressing his anguish over the ‘extremely slow’ ‘decision-making process within the company’. He requested Mistry to execute either the Ola or Uber proposal and if possible, both, as it would be a ‘real shot-in-the-arm’ for Tata Motors. However, neither deal materialized.

Several other attempts, such as a tie-up with a Sri Lankan automobile company to launch an all-new GenX Nano Automatik for the Sri Lankan market, and one with a Coimbatore-based firm, Jayem Automotives, to manufacture and market the electric version of the Nano, were made. But none succeeded.

**Apathetic Mistry**

The Nano’s problems intensified with Mistry’s criticism of the project after he was replaced in 2016. A day after Ratan took over as interim chairman, in a five-page letter to the Tata Sons board, Mistry wrote, as quoted in a business newspaper, that the Nano was, in fact, a loss-making entity. He also asserted that the ‘cost of Nano’s production’ had always been higher than the proposed Rs 1 lakh tag and that the ‘project needed to be shut down if Tata Motors’ had any intention to ‘remain profitable’.

Mistry further asserted, ‘This product has consistently lost money, peaking at Rs 1,000 crores. As there is no line of sight to profitability for the Nano, any turnaround strategy for the company requires [the group] to shut it down. Emotional reasons alone have kept us away from this crucial decision.’ With the Nano already struggling to stay afloat, these comments did not help.

On 4 November 2016, Tata Motors issued a statement to the BSE that despite setting up a plant with a capacity to produce 2.5 lakh Nano cars per annum, volumes had failed to materialize. The company attributed this to a host of factors including production delays and public perception, and said: ‘In a highly price-sensitive segment of the market, coupled with low volumes, it has been a loss making product.’

Mistry continued to attack the project. In August 2017, he talked about ‘the practice of lending without adequate risk assessment, particularly in the